

The Great Wooden Horse

The windswept shores of Troy stretch along a bright Aegean sea, where wooden ships with painted eyes lie beached on the long sand and a great city of honey-coloured walls stands proud on the hill above. For a long while two camps, the weary seafarers on the beach and the proud city behind its gates, have been caught in a tired old quarrel that neither truly wants. Across the wine-dark sea lies the long road home, full of wonders: a loyal old hound, a keeper of the winds, and lonely sea-singers on the rocks. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is clever, brave, and keeps faith with a friend. The grandest deeds are done not with spears but with a good idea and a kind heart, and the oldest quarrels often end with a single brave act of friendship.



The Great Wooden Horse

Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only brave new ideas to try.

Before you begin

For a long, long time the two camps on the windswept shores of Troy have been cross with each other. The seafarers live in tents and wooden ships along the beach. The proud city sits up on the hill behind great honey-coloured walls, with its gates shut tight. Nobody quite remembers how the quarrel began. The truth is, everyone is rather tired of it, and both camps secretly wish it would just stop.

Odysseus the Clever calls you to him. He has a curly beard and a kind, twinkly smile, and in his hands he holds a tiny wooden horse. "I have a clever idea," he says. "Let us build a great wooden horse, as big as a house. But we will not fill it with soldiers. We will fill it with gifts and music and friendship, and roll it to the gates as a happy surprise. That is how we end the quarrel."

He gives you three gifts: a basket of honey and figs, Penelope's thread, and a conch horn. Then he smiles. "On these shores we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being clever, brave, and loyal to a friend."

What is your hero name? Will you carry Cleverness, Courage, or Loyalty?

Step 1: Building the Horse

On the beach lie heaps of smooth wooden planks. The horse must be built tall and strong, so it stands up without wobbling, with a little door in its side.

The builders scratch their heads. How many planks for each leg? How do you fit the curved pieces so they balance? Penelope's thread can measure each piece, and careful counting will tell you how many you need.

How could you build it so it stands up straight? Could you measure with the thread? Could you count the planks together? Try something and see.

When you fit the pieces and balance them just right, the great wooden horse rises up on its wheels, tall and proud and steady. Everyone cheers.

Step 2: Filling It with Friendship

Now the horse is built, and its little door stands open. What should you put inside? Not soldiers, never soldiers. The whole idea is a kind surprise.

You look at all the lovely things on the beach: the basket of figs, garlands of bright flowers, and a little drum for happy music.

What kind things would make the best surprise? Which gifts say "let us be friends"? Choose together. There is no wrong answer here.

When you tuck the figs, the flowers, and the little drum inside, the horse feels warm and welcoming, like a present waiting to be opened. It is the friendliest horse anyone has ever seen.

Step 3: The Surprise at the Gates

Slowly, slowly, you roll the great horse up the hill to the city gates. The folk on the walls peer down. They look wary and weary. The gates stay shut. For a moment, your heart thumps.

But this is not a fight. It is a gift. You only need to show them it is kind.

What could you do to show them you come as friends? You have the conch horn to sound a warm hello. You could open the horse's door and share the figs. What do you try?

When you sound the conch horn and open the door, out tumble figs and flowers and a merry drumbeat. The watchful folk gasp, then laugh, then beam. Slowly, the great gates creak open at last.

The Long Quarrel Ends

The city folk come down from their walls, and the seafarers come up from the beach, and they meet in the middle, a little shy. Then someone shares a fig. Someone beats the little drum. Someone laughs, and then everyone laughs.

The two camps spread out a great feast together, side by side, as if the quarrel had never been. Out on the calm water, Thetis the Sea-Mother lifts her head from the waves and smiles. You did it together. You were clever, you were brave, and you were loyal, and the oldest quarrel of all has ended with a kind surprise. Well done, heroes of Troy.

The Story in Pictures



Two small heroes and friendly seafarers building a great wooden horse on the beach, measuring planks with a thread and fitting the pieces together.



Two small heroes filling the open belly of a great wooden horse with baskets of figs, flower garlands and a little drum, smiling as they work.



A great garlanded wooden horse at the tall gates of a honey-coloured city wall, wary city folk peeking down, two small heroes below sounding a conch and offering figs.



The two camps feasting together on the beach at sunset around the garlanded wooden horse, seafarers and city folk sharing figs, a clever kindly sea-captain smiling among them.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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